



Copilot Credit Governance

A practical guide to where Copilot Credits go, who can stop them, and which controls are real.

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COVERS



Copilot Studio



Cowork



Work IQ API

WHAT WE COVER

- 1 Where the credits go by default
- 2 Fix one — the per-environment checkbox
- 3 Fix two — Managed Environments as policy
- 4 A workaround that half-works
- 5 Cowork and Work IQ versus agents
- 6 What actually stops the spend

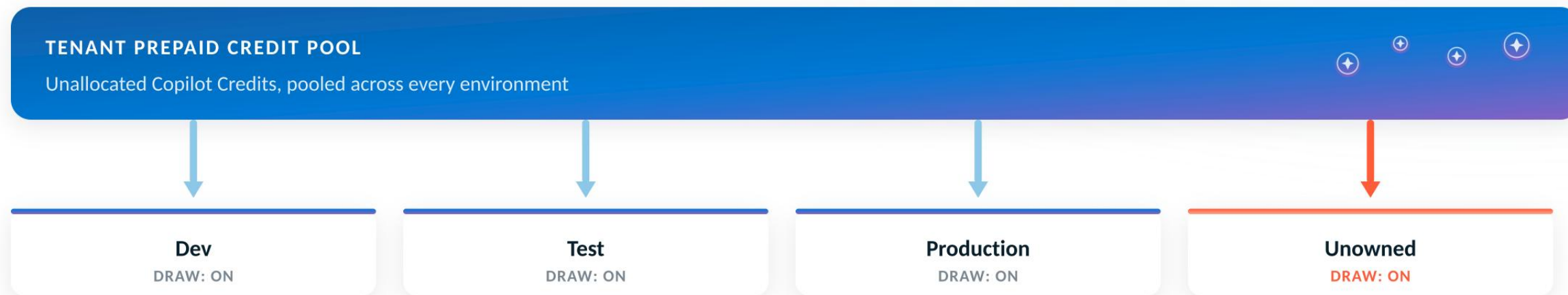
Two admin centres, one credit pool, and only some of the controls you would expect.





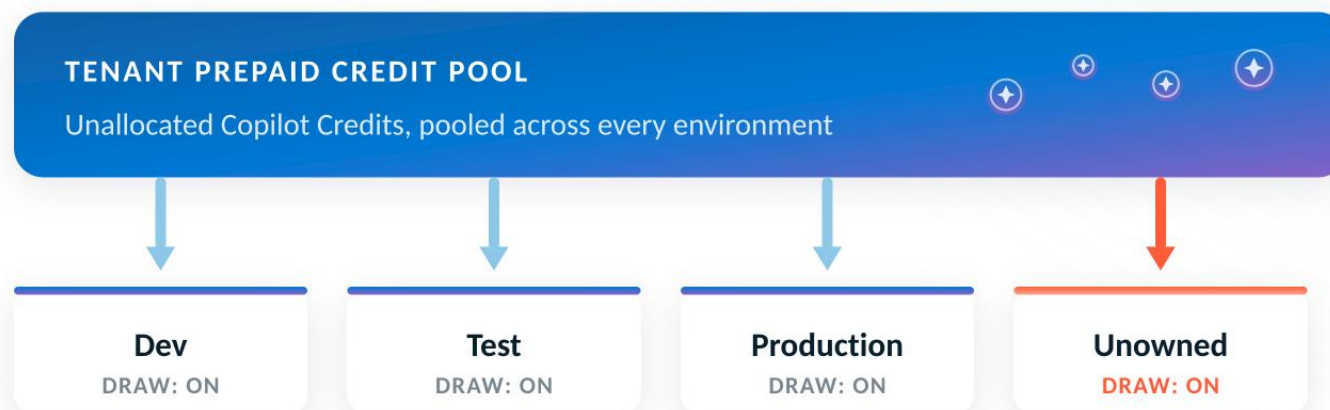
Every environment has a tap into your credit pool

Open by default. On every environment. Including the ones nobody remembers creating.





Nobody turned this on. It was already on.



Straight from the documentation

"Draw from the available capacity in my tenant" is selected by default for eligible Copilot Studio environments whenever no allocation configuration exists.

Why it bites harder now

GitHub Copilot harness agents bill for all usage — building, testing, evaluating and running. No Microsoft 365 Copilot licence covers any of it, and developer and trial environments move to usage-based billing on 1 September 2026.



The supported fix is a checkbox

Power Platform admin centre

Licensing › Products › Copilot Studio › Manage Copilot Credits

Environment: AGENTS - PROD

Copilot Credit allocation: 5,000 credits

Capacity overages: ☐ Draw from the available capacity in my tenant
leave this cleared

Save

Prepaid draw



Capped at the allocation. With no allocation at all, the environment cannot touch tenant capacity.

STOPPED

Pay-as-you-go



Untouched. A linked billing plan keeps metering to the Azure subscription regardless.

STILL OPEN

No Managed Environment required

A plain per-environment setting. Set it, and the tap closes for that environment alone.

An allocation alone is not a boundary. It still leaks if the environment can keep drawing behind it.





Managed Environments turns it from a setting into a policy

1

Turn on Managed Environments

On the environments that host your agents. An entitlement, not a purchase.

2

Put them in an environment group

Group the agent environments so one policy covers all of them.

3

Publish the cost-control rule

Cost controls — Draw from tenant credit pool. Set it off and publish.

What the rule takes away

-  It governs every environment in the group — including ones added later.
-  The environment-level checkbox turns read-only in the admin centre.
-  Programmatic requests cannot override it either.
-  Remove an environment from the group and it keeps the last value, but becomes editable again.



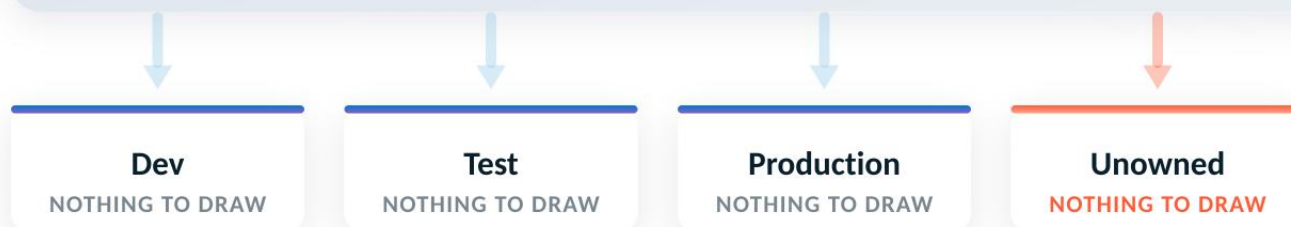
A trick that half-works

The idea I tested

Allocate the entire tenant pool to one dummy environment. Nothing is left unallocated, so nothing can be drawn.

TENANT PREPAID CREDIT POOL

Fully allocated to a dummy environment. Nothing left to draw.



Why I am not recommending it



- It does nothing about pay-as-you-go — the bill that actually matters here.
- A tenant-wide lever for an environment-level problem.
- Microsoft documents the cross-drain: capacity allocated to environments reduces what is available to Cowork and Work IQ API.
- Credits reset monthly and never carry over. The parking needs upkeep.



The control you get for Cowork, you do not get for agents

Microsoft 365 admin centre › Cost Management



Spending policies scoped by Entra security group, with tenant, group and per-user monthly credit limits, plus alerts and hard caps.



Cowork



Work IQ API

PER-USER LIMITS

Power Platform admin centre



Environment allocation, tenant draw, the group rule and a per-agent limit. No per-user control.



Copilot Studio agents

NO PER-USER LIMITS

Why the gap exists — and what it costs you

Agent consumption is attributed to an environment and an agent, never to a person. That is the same design decision that puts an autonomously triggered run outside the Microsoft 365 Copilot licence: there is no signed-in identity behind it. No identity to bill also means no identity to cap.

So for agents your blast radius is the environment, not the user. Design environments as budget boundaries, because that is the only boundary you get.



What actually stops the spend

Environment allocation

Sizes the budget. Not a boundary on its own.



PARTIAL

Draw from tenant capacity, off

Closes prepaid draw for that environment.



STOPS PREPAID

Environment group rule

Same control, applied as policy and locked.



STOPS PREPAID

Agent limit + Stop usage

Turns the agent off at the limit.



TRUE HARD STOP

Per-user spending policy

Caps one person's monthly credits. Cowork and Work IQ API only.



NOT FOR AGENTS

Azure budgets and alerts

Notifies finance. Does not stop consumption.



ALERTS ONLY



Copilot Credits



Real money on the Azure bill



Cowork



Work IQ API

Do this before 1 September

Filter the Harness column in your agent inventory to GitHub Copilot, find which environments those agents live in, then close the tap on every one.

